

SNAKE NOIR: THE UNPRINTED PANEL

Hackathon Game Proposal | Fiverr Hyderabad | Theme: Comic, Light, Twist

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1. Game Concept

Snake Noir: The Unprinted Panel is a short, browser-based detective puzzle that turns the familiar trail mechanic of *Snake* into an interactive comic-book mystery. The player controls **Detective Snake**, a moving trail of light trapped inside the final, unfinished panel of a black-and-white detective comic. The earlier panels show that a crime has happened, but the last panel was never printed, so the culprit and the events of the crime stay hidden in darkness.

Core loop: MOVE > ILLUMINATE > DISCOVER > RECONSTRUCT

The investigation hides one contradiction. At first the trail is a source of light that reveals evidence. At the midpoint the rules reverse: the world becomes visible, but the trail turns into **dark comic ink that erases evidence**. The player must rethink everything they found, and the final panel reveals that the detective is connected to the crime.

2. Gameplay and Game Flow

- Move with **WASD / Arrow Keys** (or swipe on mobile) across a single-screen, grid-based comic panel that starts almost completely dark.
- The glowing trail lights nearby cells, revealing hidden clues, objects and dialogue. Collected evidence fills a lightweight **case board** used to build a theory.
- At the midpoint the **rule reversal** triggers: the panel lights up, the trail becomes ink, and crossing evidence marks it as **LOST** in the case board.
- The player reinterprets the clues, reconstructs the crime from what survives, and reaches the final reveal. A full round takes about 2 to 3 minutes and is easy to replay.

Flow: ENTER > EXPLORE > ILLUMINATE > FIND CLUES > BUILD A THEORY > TWIST > ERASE / RECONSTRUCT > FINAL REVELATION

3. The Three Mandatory Themes

Theme	Role in the game	How it is implemented
COMIC The world	The whole game lives inside an unfinished comic page, not a comic-styled menu.	1950s black-and-white graphic-novel look, panels, speech bubbles, narration boxes, halftone textures, bold lettering, and POW! / BAM! / GASP! effects. Small visual jokes keep the noir approachable.
LIGHT The core mechanic	Darkness = unknown. Light = information. Light decides what the player knows.	The snake trail acts as a moving flashlight. Evidence, objects and dialogue appear only when illuminated, so exploring directly becomes investigating.
TWIST The rules reverse	The same movement now has the opposite effect, felt through play rather than a cutscene.	Before: Movement > Light > Evidence revealed. After: Movement > Dark Ink > Evidence erased. The final panel recasts the player's earlier actions as part of the crime.

A comic provides the world, light reveals the mystery, and the twist changes what the player's light means.

4. Player Experience and Design Goal

The intended arc is **Curiosity > Discovery > Confidence > Surprise > Realization**. The player first thinks "*I'm solving a mystery*," then "*Why is my trail destroying the evidence?*", and finally "*I was part of the mystery all along*." The goal is one memorable "I didn't expect that" moment that a judge can describe in a single sentence.

5. Prototype Scope and Technical Plan

The prototype delivers **one complete mystery** rather than a large, unfinished game.

Prototype features	Technology and delivery
One playable comic panel Snake-style grid movement Dynamic light trail and darkness mask Hidden evidence and dialogue Clue / reconstruction case board Mid-game rule reversal and evidence-erasing ink Final reveal, restart and replay	Engine: HTML5 Canvas + JavaScript (single-file runtime) Controls: WASD / Arrows, plus touch and swipe for mobile browsers Audio: Web Audio API procedural sounds (clicks, clue chimes, ink hiss) and/or free-to-use assets Pipeline: Code on GitHub > itch.io browser build > playable on desktop and mobile with no install

Deliberately out of scope: multiplayer, accounts, databases, complex AI, 3D, and open-world content. This keeps a solo build finishable and stable during judging.

6. Theme Justification and Judging Fit

Likely judging area	How Snake Noir delivers
Theme fit (Comic, Light, Twist)	All three are structural: comic is the world, light is the mechanic, and the twist rewrites the mechanic itself.
Innovation	A classic mechanic with one flipped rule: the trail that reveals evidence later destroys it.
Gameplay and polish	Simple controls, instant understanding, a short round, and consistent comic visuals and audio feedback.
Technical execution	Lightweight canvas build, runs in any modern browser, desktop and mobile, shipped as a public link.
Demo and impact	The twist is visible within the first minute of a demo and is easy to retell in one sentence.

7. Build Plan and Risk Control

Phase	Focus	Outcome
Phase 1 (first third)	Grid movement, trail, darkness and light mask	Playable core Snake loop
Phase 2 (middle)	Evidence, case board, midpoint rule reversal, erasing ink	Complete mystery with the twist working
Phase 3 (final third)	Comic art, speech bubbles, sound, mobile swipe, itch.io upload	Polished, deployable build
Final hours	Bug fixing, pitch rehearsal, no new features	Stable demo and a clear 60-second pitch

- **Fallback:** if the full erasing mechanic runs late, erased clues are marked as "lost" and change the final reconstruction, which still delivers the twist.
- **Twist safety:** the reveal that the detective is connected to the crime is simple to execute and clear in a short build.

8. Future Potential

The prototype can grow into a series of short comic mysteries, each with a different rule-changing twist, plus new cases, branching clues, multiple endings, character dialogue, and mobile app packaging. The hackathon version stays focused on proving the core experience.

MOVE. ILLUMINATE. DISCOVER. QUESTION EVERYTHING.
COMIC. LIGHT. TWIST. One panel. One mystery. One trail of evidence.